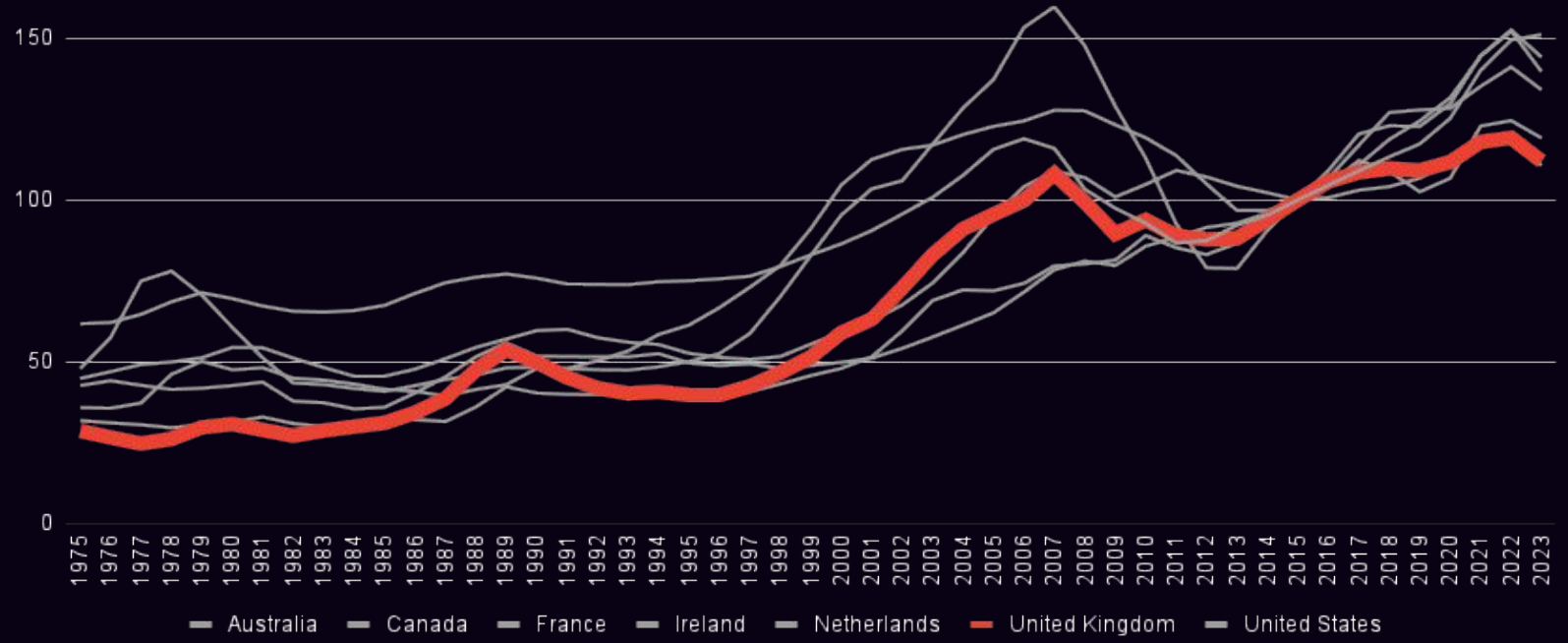
Chart-astrophe

The numbers behind Britain's housing crisis

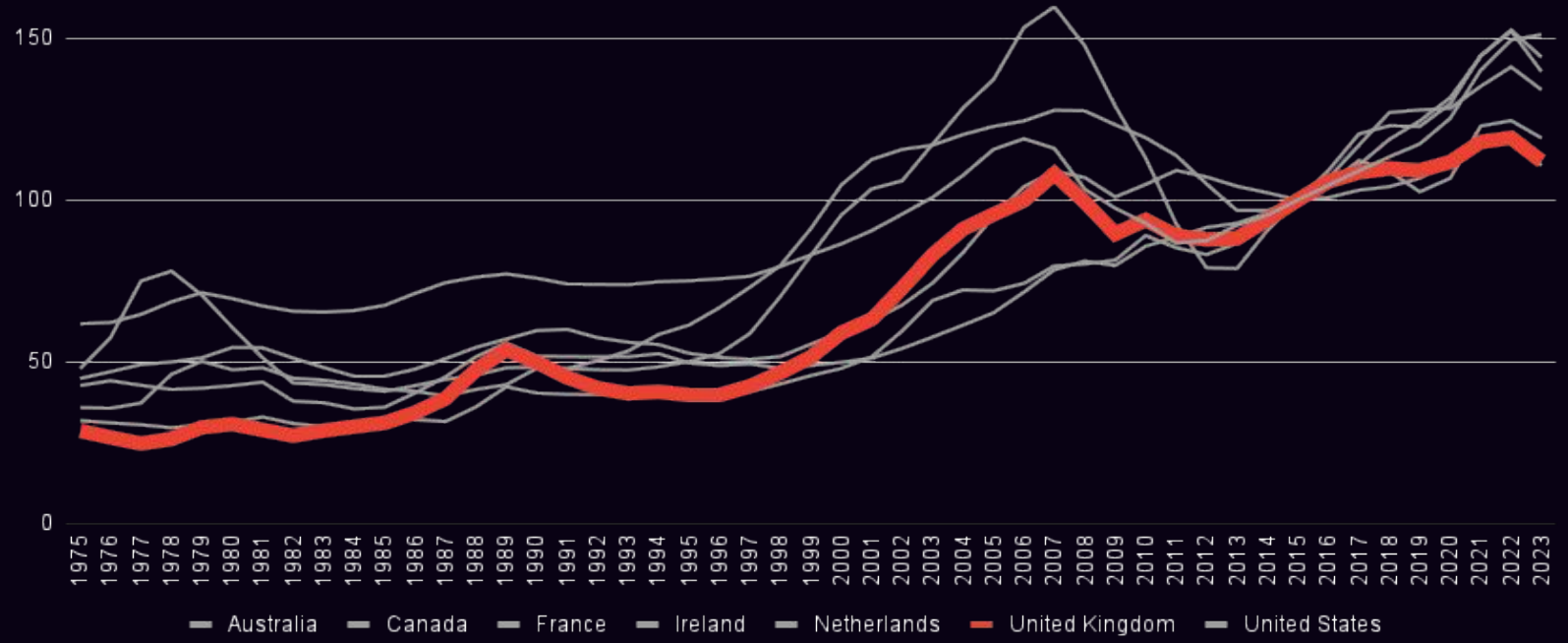
Lauren Thomas

Real house price indices



Source: OECD. Indexed to 2015.

Real house price indices



Source: OECD. Indexed to 2015.

Increase after adjusting for inflation, 1993-2023

+198%

+183%

+180%

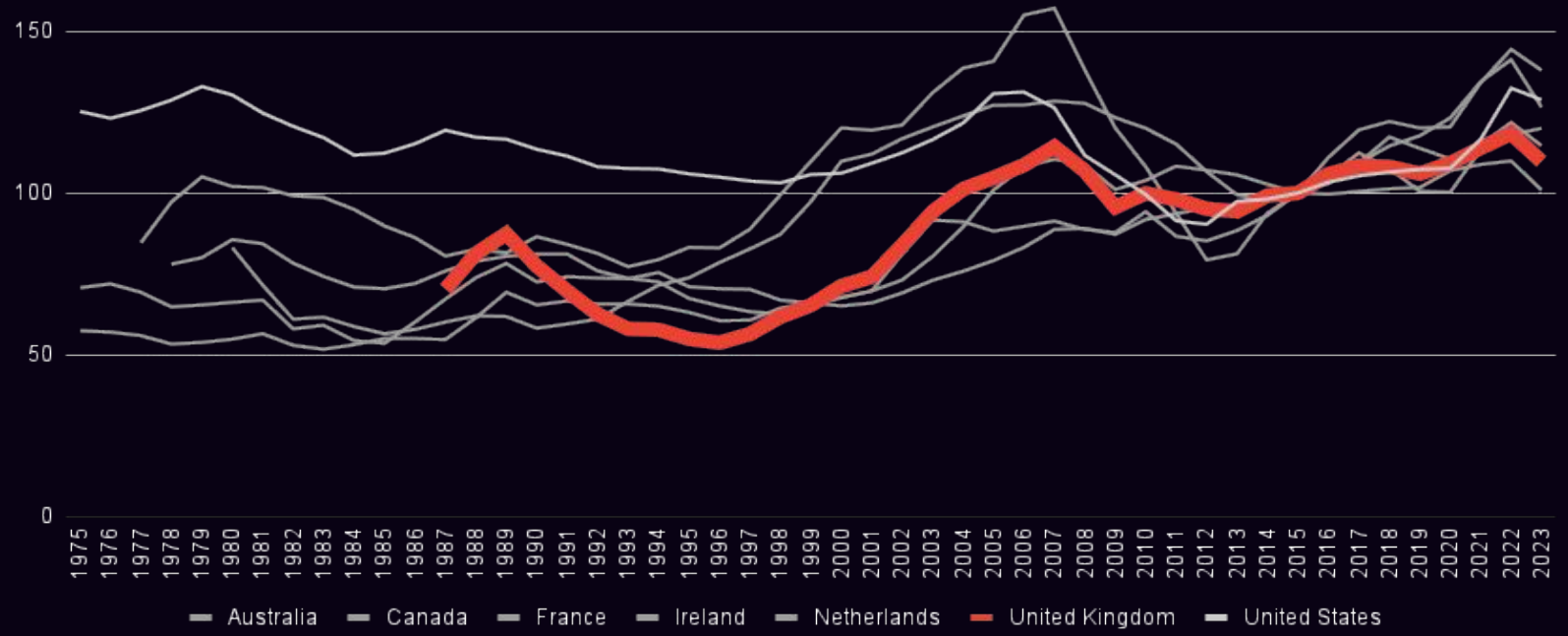
+178%

+162%

+105%

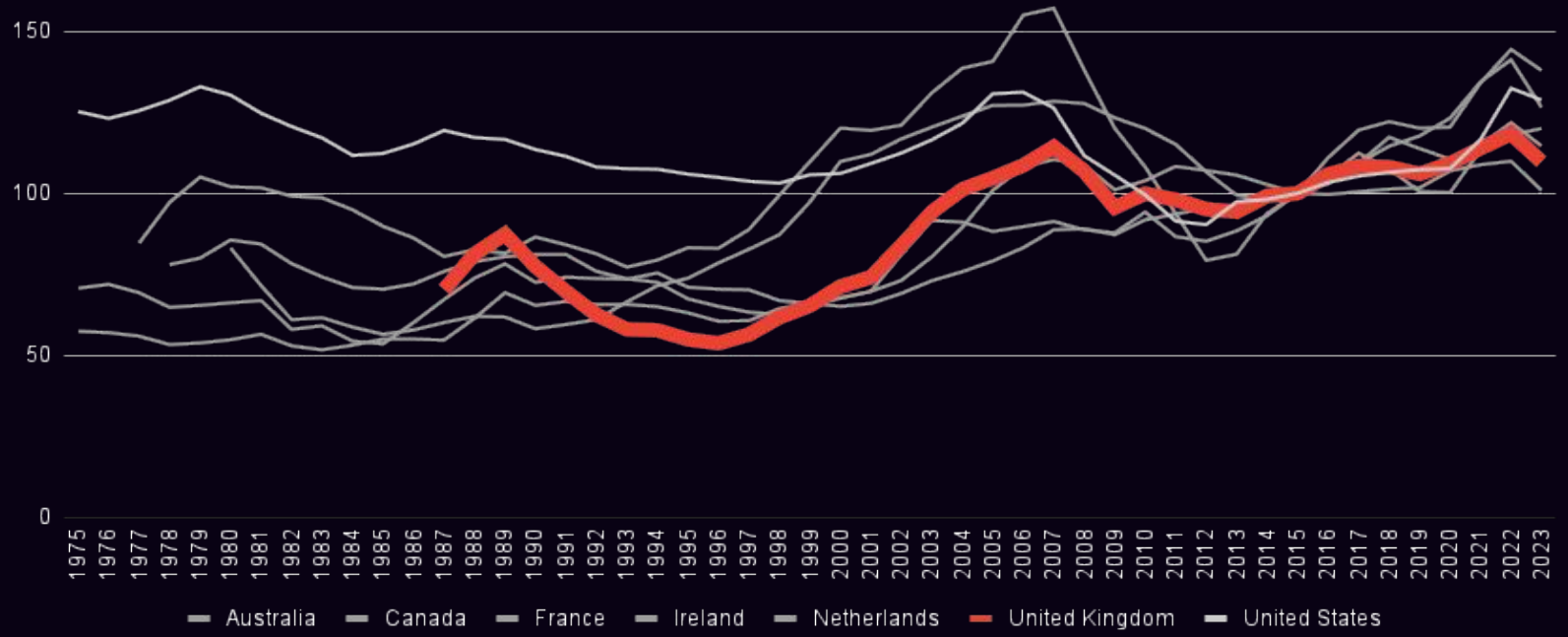
+98%

Price-to-income ratio



Source: OECD.
Indexed to 2015.

Price-to-income ratio



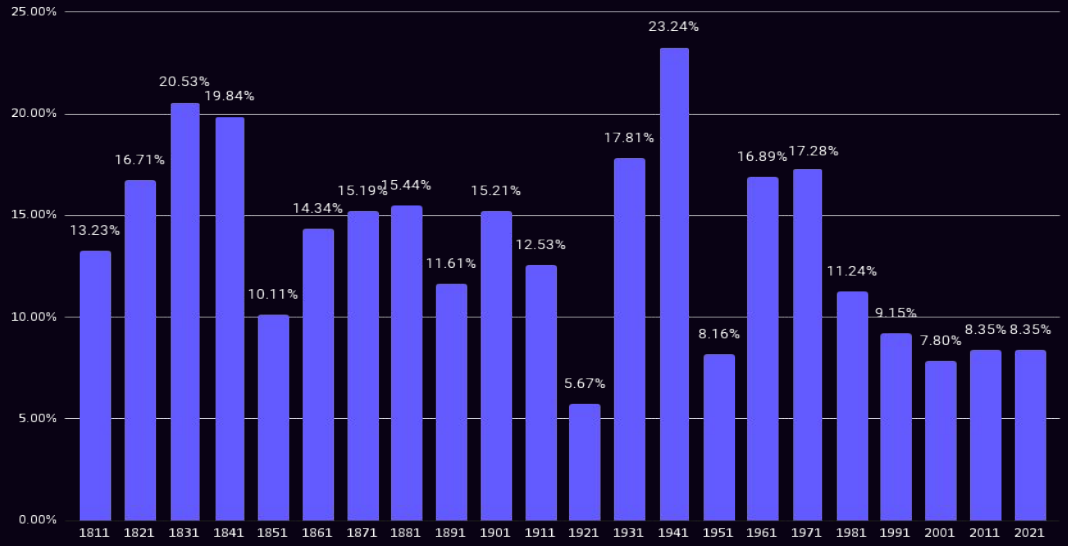
Source: OECD.
Indexed to 2015.

Increase, 1993-2023



The UK stopped building after the 1970s

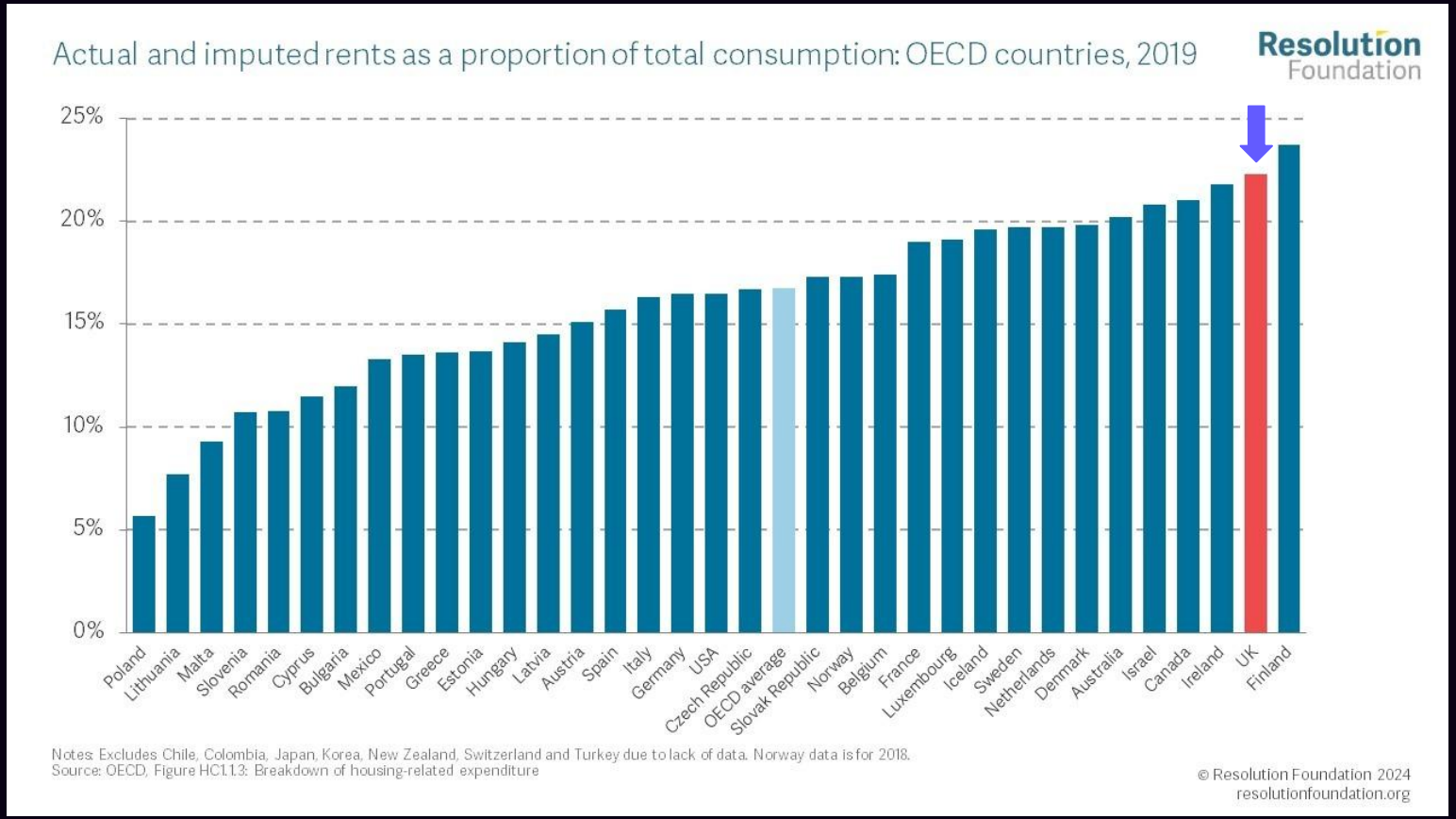
Percent increase in housing stock in UK



Source: Holmans, ONS. Sourced from Tony Blair Institute, “The Urgent Need for More Homes.”

But price-to-income ratios aren’t the whole story, because those are mediated by interest rates

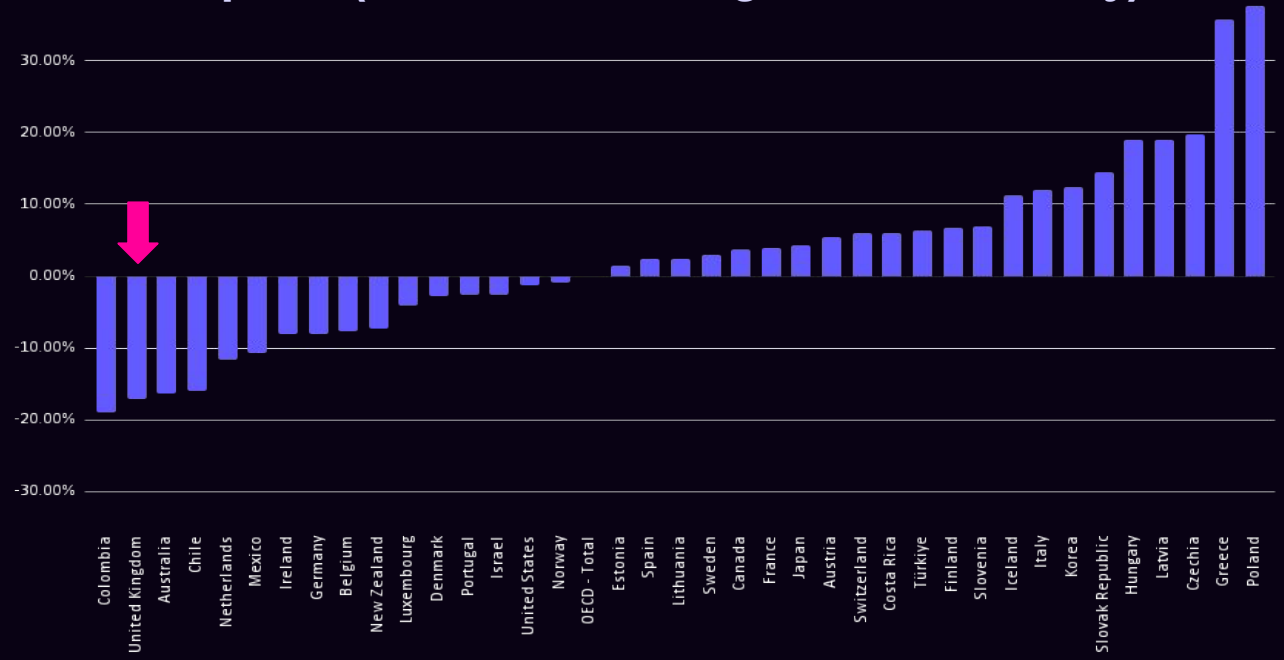
The UK's rents relative to consumption are amongst the most expensive in the world



And even a basic comparison of housing cost underestimates the problem…

The UK consumes less & worse housing than expected given its overall prosperity

Percent difference between housing consumption and total consumption (relative to average OECD country)



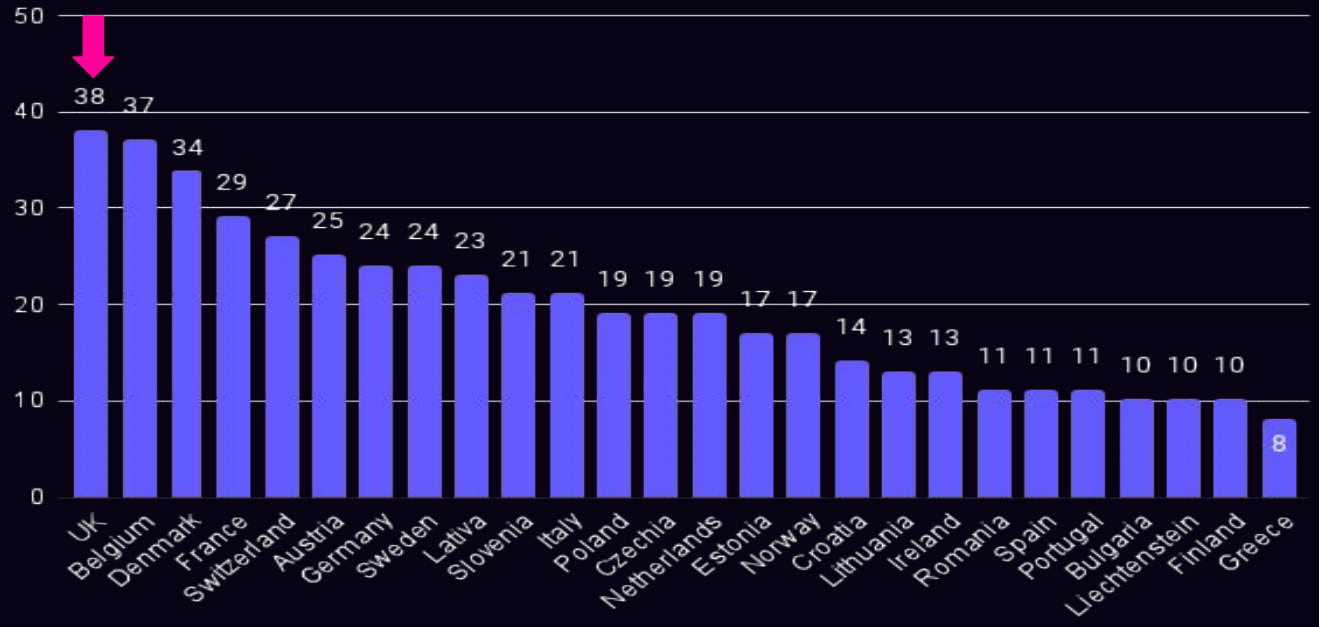
Source: OECD, 2017 PPP Benchmark Results, Table 1.10. Overall prosperity = 'actual individual consumption.' Housing consumption includes utilities. Sourced from Resolution Foundation Housing Outlook Q1 2024.

The UK's houses are expensive…



The UK's houses are expensive, old…

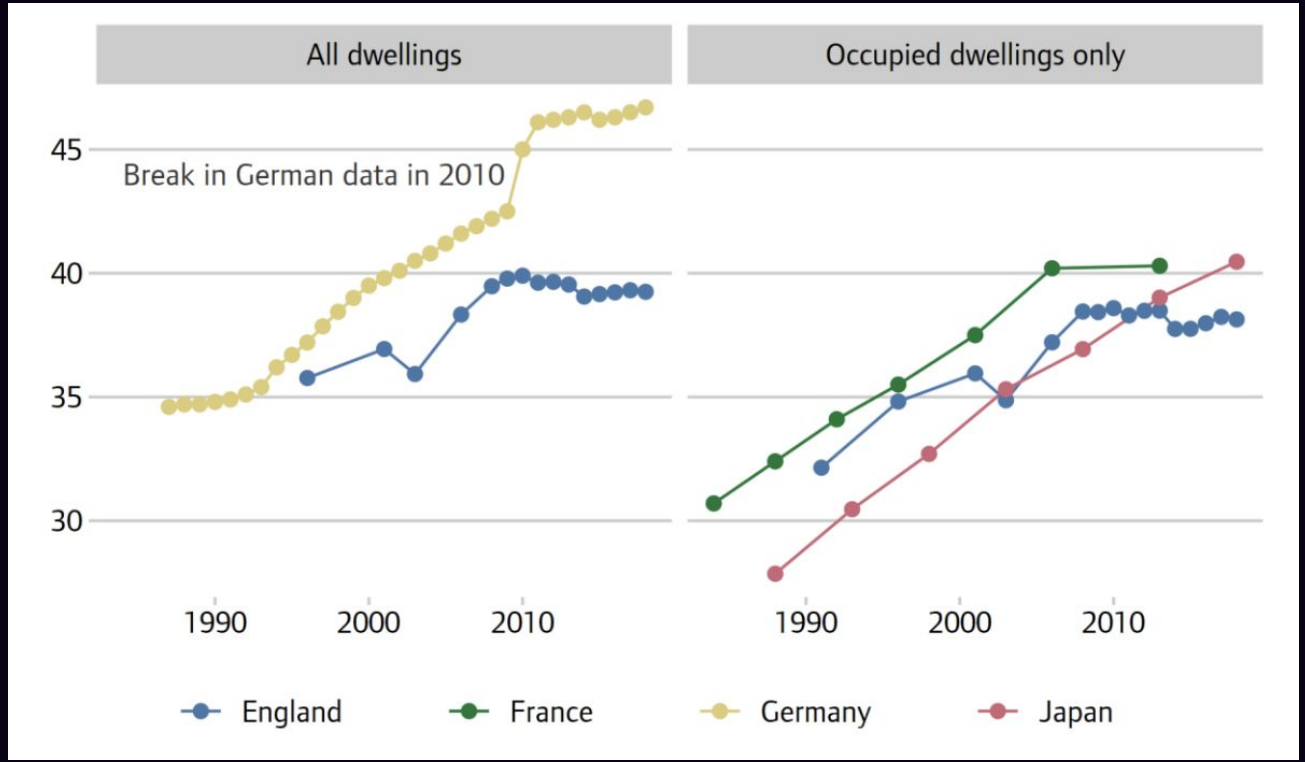
Proportion of residential dwellings built before 1946



Source: Resolution Foundation Q1 Housing Outlook

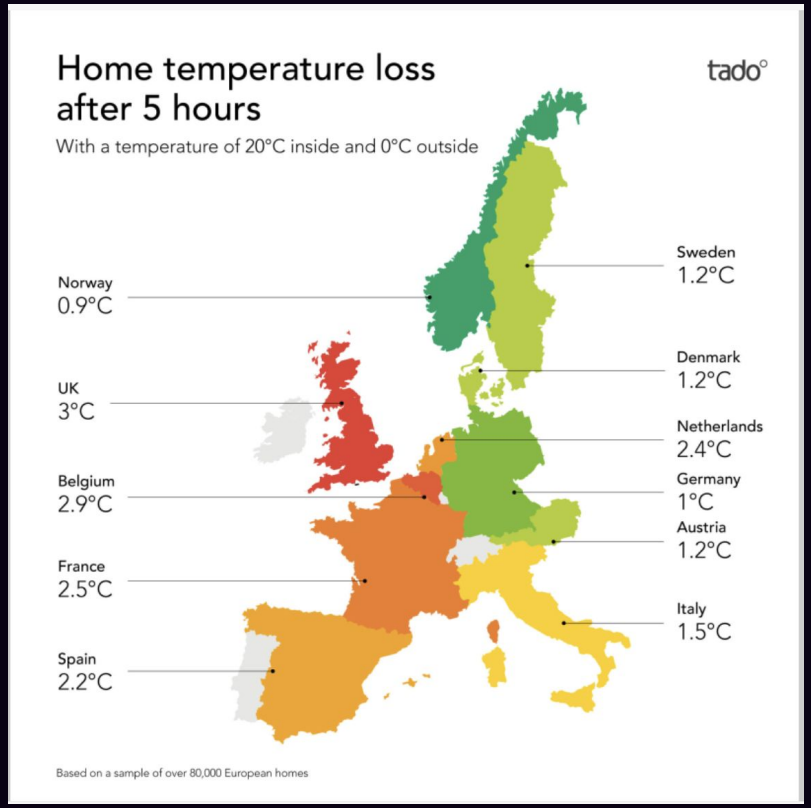
The UK's houses are expensive, old, small…

England's dwelling space (m2 per person) has lagged behind Japan, France, & Germany



Source: Greater London Authority, Housing Research Note: An analysis of housing floorspace per person

The UK's houses are expensive, old, small, and poorly insulated



Source: Tado study

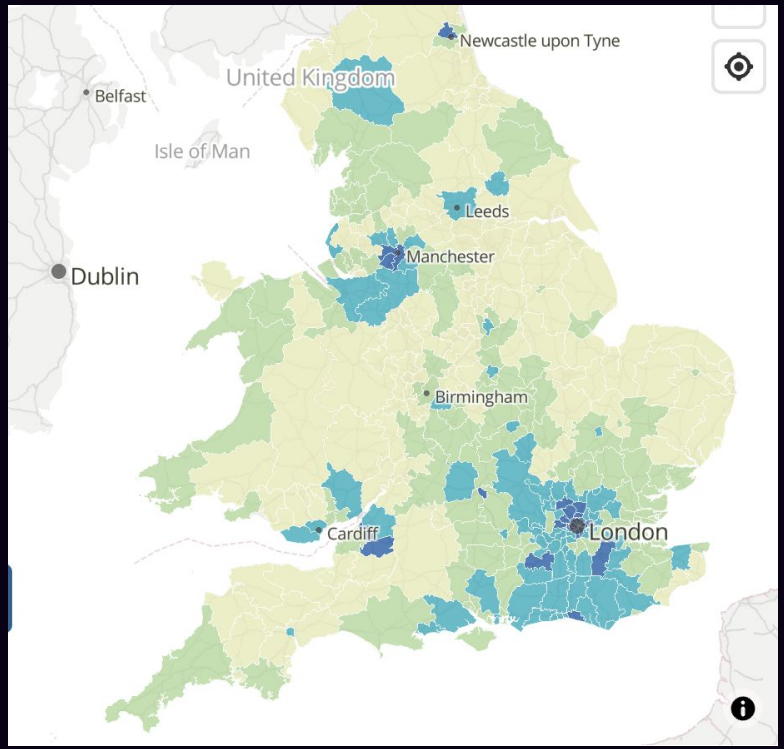
But the problem is not equal across the UK

London & the SE bear the brunt of the problem



London & the SE bear the brunt of the problem

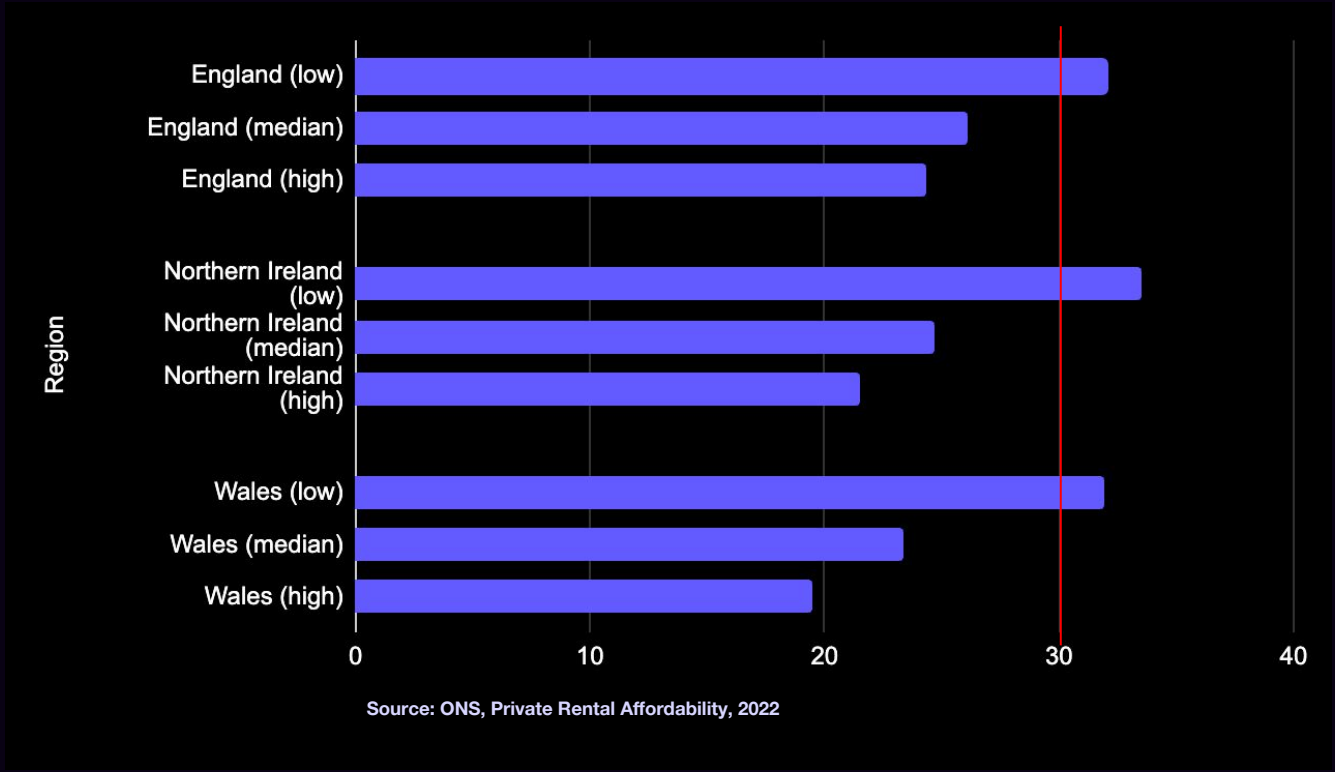
Rental affordability by local authority



Source: ONS, Private Rental Affordability, 2023

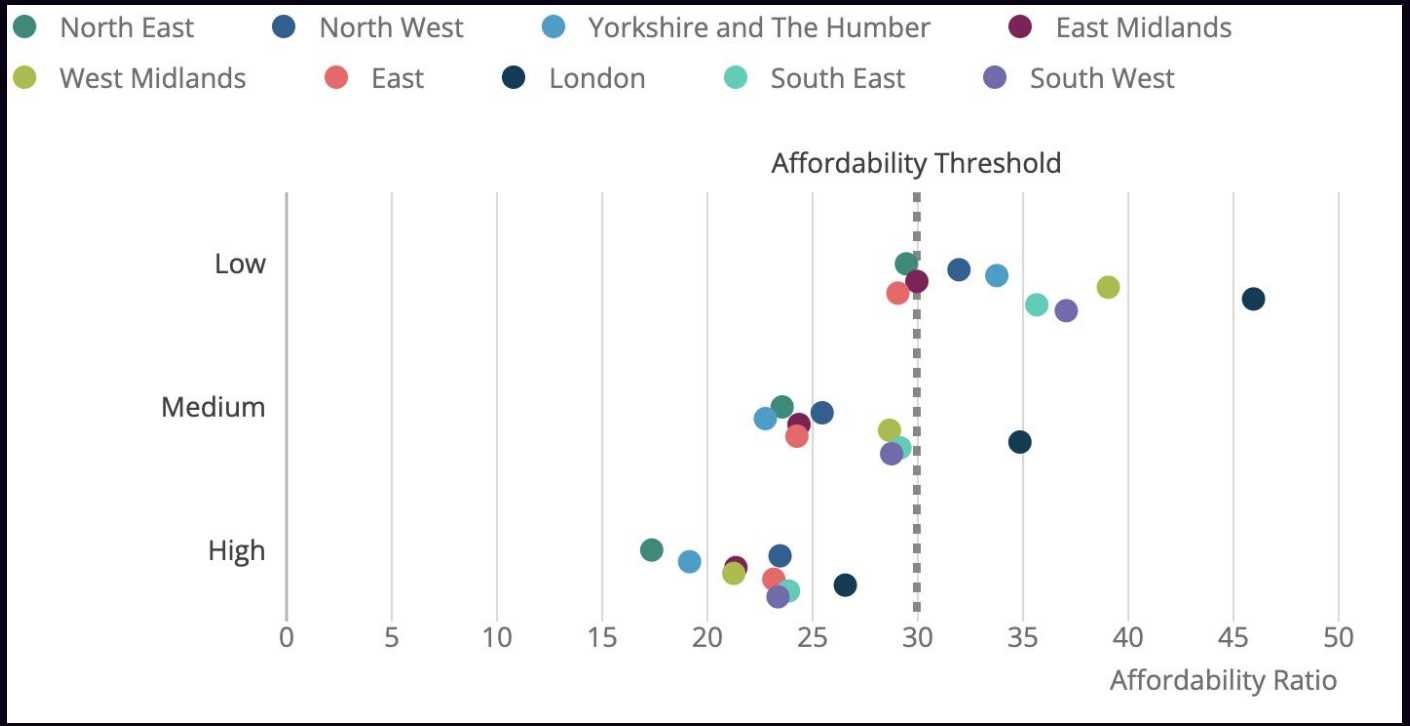
The rental crisis hurts those on lowest incomes the most…despite their lower rents

Rental affordability by income: Ratios of low, median, and high rents to their equivalent rental income quartile



The crisis is particularly acute for low-income households in London

Ratios of low, median, and high rents to their equivalent rental income quartile by local authority



Source: ONS, Private Rental Affordability, 2022

What can you do?

Get involved!

- PricedOut
- YIMBY Alliance / Islington YIMBY
- ACORN

Learn more!

- Stephen Hoskins, YIMBY Lit Review
- Order Without Design: How Markets Shape Cities (Alain Bertaud)

Write to your MP & on planning applications & local plans

Come talk to me afterwards!